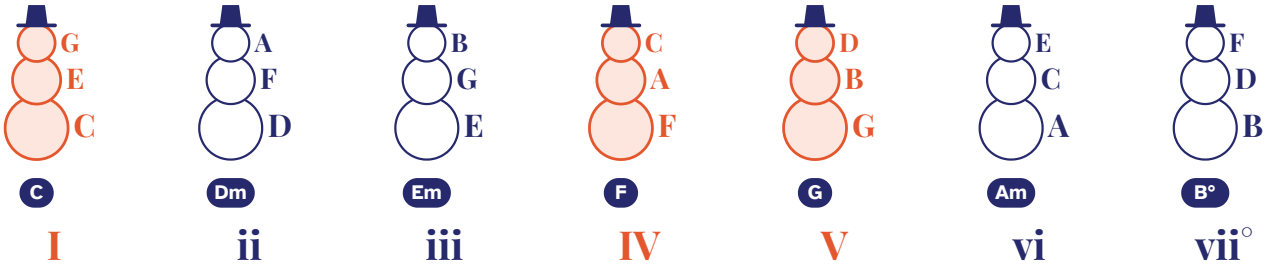
PART IV · HARMONY · 3

Chords in a key
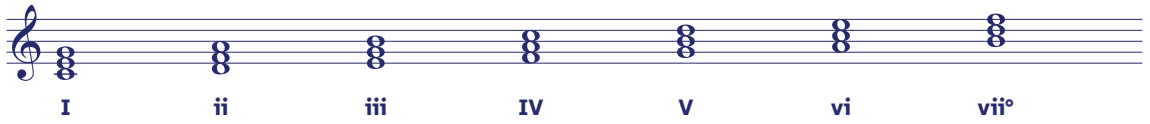
Build a triad on every note of a scale and you have the chords of that key. **Roman numerals** name each one by its place in the scale: I on the 1st note, IV on the 4th, V on the 5th. Capitals are major, small numerals are minor, and small with ° is diminished.

THE SECRET

Build a snowman on every note of the scale: I, IV and V are the strongest.



One snowman on every note: I, IV and V do most of the work



The seven chords of C major. Only white keys, so the kinds come out as on p. 90.

NUMERAL	NAME	KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	IN C	IN G
I	tonic	major	3 + 2	C	G
ii	supertonic	minor	2 + 3	Dm	Am
iii	mediant	minor	2 + 3	Em	Bm
IV	subdominant	major	3 + 2	F	C
V	dominant	major	3 + 2	G	D
vi	submediant	minor	2 + 3	Am	Em
vii°	leading note	diminished	2 + 2	B°	F♯°

The same in every major key: I, IV and V are major; ii, iii and vi are minor; vii° is diminished. First met: I, IV and V at Levels 1–2; the other chords from about Level 4.

The three primary chords
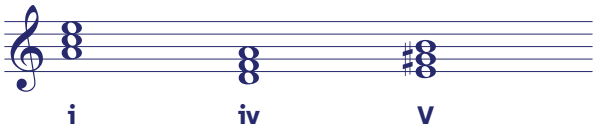
I, IV and V are the strongest chords of a key. Between them they hold **every note of the scale**: C E G, F A C, G B D. That is why so many tunes need only these three.

THINK OF IT I is home. IV is a visit next door. V is the walk back, already looking at the front door: it wants to go home to I. Play C, F, G, C and hear it.

PART IV · HARMONY · 3 · CONTINUED

In a minor key

In A minor the three main chords are **i** (A minor), **iv** (D minor) and **V**: E G♯ B, made major by the **raised 7th**, G♯, which pulls up to the home note A. Check: E G♯ B is 3 + 2, major.



A minor: i, iv and V. The G♯ makes V major.

Which chord holds the note?

NOTE IN C	C	D	E	F	G	A	B
Chord	I or IV	V	I	IV	I or V	IV	V

The same idea works in every key: find which of I, IV and V holds the note.

EXAMPLE 1

Find I, IV and V in G major



1. **Count up the scale:** G A B C D. The 1st note is G, the 4th C, the 5th D.
2. **Build a triad on each,** using the key signature: the F is F♯.
3. **Check with the keys between:** all three are 3 + 2, major.

In G major: **I = G**, **IV = C**, **V = D** (D F♯ A).

GAME

Which numeral?



All in C major. Count up the scale from C to find each chord's number.

Answer: 1 IV · 2 V · 3 vi · 4 ii.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Left hand: I IV V I.

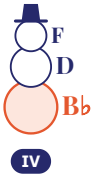
C, F, G, C, one chord per bar, four beats each. The three primary chords: nearly every nursery tune fits them.

PART IV · HARMONY · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Find I, IV and V in F major





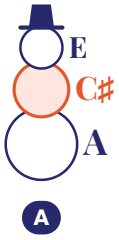


1. **Count up the scale:** F G A B♭ C. The 1st note is F, the 4th B♭, the 5th C.
2. **Build a triad on each,** with the key signature's B♭.
3. **Check:** all three are 3 + 2, major.

In F major: **I = F**, **IV = B♭**, **V = C**.

EXAMPLE 3

Find V in D minor



1. **The 5th note** of D minor is A.
2. **Build the triad:** A C E.
3. **Raise the 7th note of the scale,** C to C♯: A C♯ E, major.

V in D minor is **A major**: the C♯ pulls up to D.

YOU KNOW THIS

The twelve-bar blues

I C	I C	I C	I C
IV F	IV F	I C	I C
V G	IV F	I C	V G

Almost every blues, and a lot of rock 'n' roll, is just **I, IV and V** in twelve bars. Learn this chart and you can play along with hundreds of songs.

Try it. Play the chart in C with your left hand, one chord per bar, four beats each.

TRAP

- × Writing every numeral big: ii, iii and vi are minor, so they are written small.
- × Forgetting the raised 7th in a minor key: V in A minor is E G♯ B, not E G B.

SEE ALSO

Four kinds of triad p. 89 · Major scales p. 69 · Cadences p. 113

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 3 · Online: Library › Chords